

INDIAN TEA CULTURE

The British began to cultivate tea in India in 1835. Since then, tea has become an integral part of the Indian culture and economy, and local customs and traditions have emerged around the beloved Indian chai.

TEA CULTIVATION

Tea had become a popular beverage in England by the 18th century, so to meet the increasing demand of the British, and break the Chinese monopoly, the British East India Company (EIC) smuggled tea seeds and skilled workers from China, and established tea

gardens in the northern part of India. It wasn't until the mid-19th century that the newly cultivated tea plants in Darjeeling and Assam were harvested and India began to supply tea to England and the other British colonies.

THE BRITISH GRADING SYSTEM

To get a good price for the tea they were selling, the British introduced a grading system for black tea based on the appearance of orthodox tea leaves, with the unbroken and unblemished whole leaf being superior to the broken leaf. This system is followed to this day in India, Sri Lanka, and Kenya. It's common for the leaves to break into smaller pieces of varying sizes during processing, especially after they have been dried, because they can become quite brittle. Once the leaves have been sifted and graded, only dust and "fannings," or tiny pieces of leaf, are left. These are considered the lowest grade, but if they are the fannings from a superior tea crop, they can be used to create popular commercial black tea blends.

The British grading system is based only on the appearance and size of the leaf, and does not evaluate the flavor, aroma, or the taste of the liquor. Some grades refer to "flowery" traits, indicating the presence of a small leaf bud in the tea leaf, while others refer to "golden" or "orange," indicating the presence of golden tips on the tea leaf buds or the color of the liquor.

WHOLE LEAF

SFTGFOP	Special Fine Tippy Golden Flowery Orange Pekoe (smallest whole leaf)
FTGFOP	Fine Tippy Golden Flowery Orange Pekoe
TGFOP	Tippy Golden Flowery Orange Pekoe
GFOP	Golden Flowery Orange Pekoe
FOP	Flowery Orange Pekoe
FP	Flowery Pekoe
OP	Orange Pekoe

BROKEN LEAF

GFBOP	Golden Flowery Broken Orange Pekoe
GBOP	Golden Broken Orange Pekoe
FBOP	Flowery Broken Orange Pekoe
BOP1	Broken Orange Pekoe One
BOP	Broken Orange Pekoe
BPS	Broken Pekoe Souchong

IN THE EARLY 1900s,
ALMOST ALL OF THE
TEA PRODUCED IN
INDIA WAS BLACK TEA

